

Philosophical Foundations — Module 04: Cognition

— Study Questions

1. What are the 4 E's of cognition? Define each briefly.
2. How does Active Inference engage with each of the 4 E's?
3. What is the core claim of radical enactivism? How does it differ from moderate enactivism?
4. Why do enactivists object to Active Inference's use of "generative models"?
5. How do Ramstead et al. argue that "Active Inference is enactive inference"?
6. Is the representation debate a substantive philosophical disagreement or a terminological dispute?
7. State the extended mind thesis (Clark & Chalmers). Give the Otto's notebook example.
8. How does the Markov Blanket paradox challenge the extended mind thesis?
9. What are nested Markov Blankets? How do they resolve the extension problem?
10. What is cognitive niche construction? Give three examples.
11. How does autopoiesis relate to the FEP? Where do they converge and diverge?
12. What is operational closure? How does the Markov Blanket formalize it?
13. How does Active Inference explain tool use as cognitive extension?
14. What is a "cultural Markov Blanket"? How does it support collective cognition?
15. Compare Varela's autopoiesis with Friston's FEP — is the FEP a formalization of autopoiesis or something different?
16. How does the FEP handle the distinction between "constitutive" and "causal" coupling?
17. Can Active Inference accommodate radical enactivism, or must one framework yield?
18. How does Sterelny's "scaffolded minds" relate to Active Inference's environmental modeling?
19. What are Heyes' "cognitive gadgets"? How might the FEP formalize them?
20. Critically evaluate: Does Active Inference genuinely integrate the 4E perspectives, or does it assimilate them into a fundamentally representationalist framework?